A contract process people can use.

Legal Operations Workflow | Sample operating model | 10 November 2026

THE OPERATING PRINCIPLE

I connect the request, the decision and the performance record. Each stage has a named owner, a clear next action and evidence of completion.

This workflow uses a fictional technology business, Aster Vale Systems Inc., to show how I would manage intake, review, signature and ongoing obligations. The USD thresholds below are sample policy choices. Every contract requires recorded human approval under the applicable delegation and execution by an authorized signer.

One process. Separate responsibilities.

Role	Accountability
Business owner	Define the purpose, value, deadline and dependencies. Make the business decision and own performance after signature.
Legal intake / reviewing counsel	Check completeness, identify issues and deviations, coordinate review and preserve the approved version.
Finance / Procurement / Deal Desk	Validate budget, pricing, payment, supplier or sales process, and financial approval authority.
Specialist owner	Resolve the relevant Privacy/Security, IP, trade-compliance, Quality or local employment question.
Authorized signer	Execute the exact released version within documented authority.
Record owner	Archive the complete signed set, assign obligations and keep the contract record current.

The handoffs I make explicit

A complete request enters review. A documented decision releases a specific version. The signed contract activates delivery, acceptance, payment, renewal and exit obligations. A change at any stage returns to the relevant owner before the next commitment.

The process design and example thresholds are illustrative. They are a framework for an organization's own policies, delegations, systems and governing contracts.

Collect the facts. Route the decision.

Evaluate all risk and value inputs together; preserve missing information.

Intake group	Required facts
Identity and paper	Request ID; requester; business owner; agreement type; exact entities; approved template or counterparty paper; document version/link; entity and signer verification.
Economics and timing	USD amount and value basis; conversion evidence if needed; related orders or known renewals; signature target; term; dependencies. An unknown amount stays unknown.
Risk facts	Personal data; controlled technology; shared-model training; unlimited liability; exclusivity/noncompete; NDA residuals; sanctions/export alert; other critical concern.
NDA eligibility	Unchanged approved mutual template; routine evaluation purpose; no extra commercial duties; established approval policy and delegation.

Sample routing rules - highest severity wins

Priority	Rule and next step
1 / RED	Any critical issue or value at least USD 250,000: senior Legal, Finance and business-owner decision, plus the relevant specialist. Keep missing inputs visible.
2 / NEEDS INPUT	No known RED, but required facts are missing, invalid or unverified: requester and Legal intake resolve the gap before execution.
3 / YELLOW	USD 100,000 to below USD 250,000, non-NDA paper, modified paper, nonroutine purpose or an unmet approval-policy gate: Legal/Finance review.
4 / GREEN	Below USD 100,000 and all approved mutual-NDA gates satisfied: enter the delegated review path. The designated human approver records the decision.

RISK BAND IS NOT THE WORKFLOW ROUTE

A low-value non-NDA can have a GREEN portfolio risk band while still requiring Legal review. No color or calculated result replaces human approval, specialist clearance or signature authority.

Critical triggers include personal data (Privacy/Security), controlled technology and export alerts (trade compliance), shared-model training, residuals, unlimited liability and commercial exclusivity. Ask every risk question before calculating a route.

Release the exact version.

Approval evidence belongs beside the document that will be signed.

I treat execution quality as a release gate. The reviewing owner reconciles the contract, its attachments and the approval record before the signer receives the final set.

Check	Evidence to retain
Parties and authority	Consistent legal names, entity types and addresses across the contract, Order, exhibits, notices and signature blocks; signer name/title and documented authority.
Complete exhibits	Every referenced SOW, DPA, SLA, specification, price list, acceptance protocol and other schedule is attached and on the approved revision.
Definitions and cross-references	Consistent party labels and defined terms; correct section references; no orphan definitions, unresolved abbreviations or conflicting document hierarchy.
Commercial consistency	Reconciled value, term, renewal, payment, delivery, acceptance, warranty and notice mechanics. Resolve Order/master conflicts expressly.
Clean final text	Resolve brackets, comments and tracked changes. Compare the clean version with the approved redline; preserve the document ID and version.
Approvals and conditions	Human Legal, specialist, financial and business decisions under the applicable delegation; conditions satisfied or expressly resolved by the authorized decision maker.
Signature and archive	Confirm every required signature, actual execution date and complete signed set. A planned signature date is a separate field.

THE RELEASE RECORD

Record who approved what, under which authority, for which document version and on what date. If the final text changes, return it to the owner whose decision is affected.

A clear exception handoff

For each open issue, retain the source clause, business consequence, proposed position, decision owner, deadline and resolution. Keep the signing step on hold until the authorized reviewer closes the release conditions.

The signature is the handoff.

Make the obligation, owner and evidence visible together.

Event / obligation	Record and action	Owner
Delivery and acceptance	Keep contractual/planned dates separate from actual dates. Retain test results, defects, written acceptance and any cure or retest.	Business owner + Quality
Invoice and payment	Match each invoice to the contractual milestone, acceptance evidence and budget. Separate actual cost, invoiced and paid; distinguish disputed amounts.	Finance + owner
Renewal and notice	Record end date, notice period, day-count basis, method, address, timezone and receipt evidence. Assign the renewal decision early.	Owner + Legal
Insurance evidence	Record policy period, insured entity, required endorsements, evidence status and renewal owner. Check any COI against the policy requirements.	Risk/Insurance + Procurement
Change, default and exit	Log change approvals, claims, cure periods and notice service. Track transition, return, deletion and open-order actions.	Owner + Legal

Notice arithmetic needs a source

Calculate a calendar-day notice date only when the relevant date and notice period are numeric, the contract specifies the basis, the notice method is recorded and the source has been checked. A business-day or ambiguous period goes to manual review with the governing calendar, holidays, receipt rules and timezone.

Evidence before payment or closure

Check the contract's acceptance trigger before treating delivery as acceptance. Match each invoice to the milestone and supporting evidence. The named reviewer records the approval or exception, then updates the next action.

A COI does not expand the underlying policy or substitute for a required endorsement. The Texas Department of Insurance FAQ is a jurisdiction-specific reference; the applicable contract and insurance requirements govern. [OPS-01]

Keep exceptions visible and owned.

A focused reporting rhythm turns the register into a working queue.

I use a contract ID across the agreement, milestones, obligations, invoices and evidence. Each report has an as-of date and a clear denominator. The useful output is the action and decision owner, not a color without context.

Review queue	Question and action
Approvals and exceptions	Which requests await facts, a reviewer or a release condition? Show queue age, owner, next action and deadline.
Renewal decisions	Which agreements expire within 90 days? Which require a notice decision sooner? Identify ambiguous notice mechanics for manual review.
Delivery and acceptance	Which milestones are late, disputed or missing evidence? Name the test owner and the cure/retest or escalation step.
Payment and budget	Which invoices lack acceptance evidence, exceed allocated budget or remain unpaid? Preserve disputed and undisputed amounts separately.
Insurance evidence	Which policies or required evidence are missing, expiring or awaiting verification? Assign the renewal or endorsement follow-up.
Change and exit	Which open changes, claims or termination actions need approval? Track handover, data return/deletion and surviving obligations.

Measures I would use

Separate turnaround on a complete request from time waiting for information. Track missing-field rate, open release conditions, overdue obligations and evidence completeness. Record the sample size, reporting date and definition of each measure.

Policy stewardship

A named owner maintains templates, thresholds, delegations and instructions. Review exceptions with the relevant teams, test boundary and missing-data cases when rules change, train the people using the process, and record the decision before expanding its scope.

[OPS-01] Texas Department of Insurance - Certificates of Insurance FAQs
https://www.tdi.texas.gov/certificates/faq.html
Source checked 10 November 2026 (Pacific). Texas-specific reference on certificate limitations; verify the relevant jurisdiction and actual policy/endorsements.